

Nada Yoga: Indian Healing Technique

Introduction

The most ancient and primitive human societies across the world have recognized the power of sound vibrations as they affect the minds and the body. The great system of Nada Yoga, an ancient practice in India works on the premise that the entire Universe around us, and we ourselves, are made of nada, that is sound vibrations. In other words, it is the movement of sound energy that forms the building block of the universe and not the matter, and not the matter of particle or quark, as had been thought of by the physicists. This realization in India had ushered in the concept of nada being worshipped as Brahmin.

Nada Yoga is an approach to sounds with reverence - not just as objects for self aggrandizement or sensual entertainment but as integral part of ones own unity with his inner and outer cosmos. It refers to the study of the powerful influence that nada exerts on ones mind or consciousness.

Nada Yoga employs nada or "resonance" for alleviating all those problems connected to mind, psyche or consciousness, but also for raising one's level of consciousness through the various subtle, psychic centers in the body, called Chakras. Having recognized the importance of music, the saints and seers of India like Thyagaraja, Kabir, Meerabai, Namdeo, Purandaradasa, Tukaram etc. have used music towards their nirvana.

The Inner and Outer Music

Nada Yoga divides music into two categories: The inner music or anahata and the outer music or ahata. While the outer music is heard through the sense organs viz., ears, where the mechanical energy is converted to electro chemical energy to be perceived by the brain, the inner music owes its reception to the subtle heart chakra, also known as anahata chakra, which is not a sensory organ.

As its name implies, anahata refers to one's own sound vibrations, which is so close to one's own self that any one else cannot simply share it. Anahata is totally personal and private exclusive to its "possessor" alone. Thus, you have your anahata and me, mine. As I can't know yours, you can't know mine! One can however listen to one's anahata and make use of it, provided one develops certain basic interest, commitment, will and patience. The system of Nada Yoga not only assures to the practitioner of inner music the resultant harmony, relaxation and joie de vivre, but also promises self-realisation, which is often, the singular goal for those who undertake meditation.

What is Anahata Nada?

The term "anahata" refers to the sound that is produced not by striking or hitting any object against any other object. It is also referred to as "unstruck" or "non-material" sound. This term is also interpreted variously. According to some authors, it refers to the cosmic sound, om, which represents a primal vibration that has evolved in to all manifestations in the universe. Others equate it with brahmari, the sound of a black bee, a sound, unbroken or unending and familiar to the practitioners of pranayama. Some even equate it with the thud, thud and thud of our heartbeats. For certain others, nada itself is anahata!

As its name implies, anahata is a sound, which is not produced through any striking. It has to be spontaneous and automatic. It is infinite, a sound without barriers or boundaries.

The Outer Music : Ahata

Unlike anahata music, the outer music is not esoteric or hidden. Unless one's hearing is impaired, anybody can listen to or appreciate the outer music. The outer music is manifold, unlike the inner music, which is unique and absolute. Realizing the tremendous possibilities for musical achievement offered by a myriad of rhythmic variations (a conservative count of 108 talas has been attempted in the Carnatic system) parent or janaka ragas (that in turn produce innumerable janya ragas), Igor Stravinsky once remarked "I know that 12 notes in each octave and the varieties of rhythms offer me opportunities that all of human genius will never exhaust."

The outer music - or music as we generally understand with its infinite varieties - affect our moods and minds in various ways. It draws our attention, affects our temperaments and behaviors too! While agitating us or relaxing, it affects us in myriads of ways. When one feels down and out, it is the music that could inject hopes or sunshine.

To cite this page:

Sumathy, Sundar & Sairam, T. V. (2005). Music Therapy Traditions in India. *Voices: A World Forum for Music Therapy*. Retrieved March 1, 2010, from http://www.voices.no/country/monthindia_march2005.html